room on the second floor of the Templar building— the same meeting room that had served the Israeli government in the early years of the state. The reason for this arrangement was to enable the IDF's high command to be near its headquarters and command posts, as opposed to dragging them to Jerusalem. The cabinet met every day to receive reports and updates, discuss domestic, foreign, and security issues, and make decisions to be carried out in real time. I participated personally in all of these meetings, from the very first day of the war.

Prime Minister Shamir was under increasing pressure from Defense Minister Arens and the top echelons of the IDF to authorize the IDF to intervene in the war, first and foremost by activating the air force against the surface-to-surface missile launchers in western Iraq that were set to launch missiles at Israel. Later on, as a ground plan developed, according to which one of the elite units would enter western Iraq in a ground operation to locate and destroy the missile launchers, the pressure on the prime minister increased even further. As long as the rockets were not landing in Israel, the discussion in the cabinet remained theoretical and focused on the question of whether, if and when the Iraqis did launch missiles against Israel, we would respond and intervene in the war. From the moment the missiles did begin to land in Israel, the question became concrete and burdensome, either directly or implicitly bringing up all of the core components of the Israeli security doctrine. These included the arguments that we had never wanted or asked a foreign power to fight our war; that the absence of an IDF response to a direct attack on Israel seriously damaged its doctrines of deterrence and decisive victory; that the principle of transferring the battle into enemy territory as soon as possible would be dissolved; and that national strength and pride would suffer a blow.

Notwithstanding all of these concerns, there were other, no less serious, considerations to take into account. The superpower of the United States, whose support plays an immense, perhaps even decisive, role in Israel's security, had asked us not to intervene in the war so that the Arab coalition built by President Bush would not fall apart; the president of the United States had committed to making a special effort to eliminate Saddam Hussein's missile-launching capability toward Israeli targets, and to immediately reinforce Israel's air defense capabilities.

Beyond all these considerations, as the press later revealed, the prime minister had the guarantee he had received from King Hussein, namely his